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Making the Case for AI Internally

A guide for nonprofit staff and leaders who want to move forward thoughtfully

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There are two distinct conversations about AI in most nonprofits right now. One is happening among staff who are quietly curious, already experimenting, and uncertain whether to say anything about it. The other is happening at the leadership or board level, where the concern is more often "are we being reckless" than "are we moving fast enough."

This document is for whoever is in the middle of that gap. Whether you are a program manager who wants to try something and needs leadership buy-in, or an ED who wants to bring a skeptical board along without overpromising, the challenge is the same: making a case that is honest about both the opportunity and the risk, and that starts somewhere small enough to actually succeed.

The strongest case for AI in a nonprofit is not about AI. It is about the specific problem you have, the specific time it costs, and the specific thing you could do with that time instead.

Start with the problem, not the technology

The most common mistake in making a case for AI internally is leading with the technology. "We should be using AI" is not a compelling argument for a board member who is worried about risk, or for a program director who is already stretched thin.

"We spend twelve hours a week writing grant reports, and we think there is a way to cut that significantly without reducing quality" is a compelling argument. The AI is the solution, not the pitch.

Before you bring this conversation to anyone whose buy-in you need, answer these questions for yourself: What specific task takes more time than it should? Who does that task, and what would they do with the time back? What is the cost of the current situation, in staff hours or in things that do not get done?

If you cannot answer those questions concretely, you are not ready to make the case yet. When you can, the case mostly makes itself.

Understanding the objections you will actually hear

The hesitation that comes up in nonprofit conversations about AI tends to cluster around a small number of real concerns. Naming them directly, and

responding to them honestly, is more effective than trying to argue around them.

"What about our clients' information? Is this safe?"

This is the right question, and it deserves a real answer. The response is not "it's fine." It is "here is specifically what we plan to use it for, here is what we will not put into it, and here is what we have looked into about how this vendor handles data." Preparation matters here more than reassurance.

"What if it produces wrong information and we send it out?"

AI tools do make mistakes, and human review is not optional for anything consequential. The honest answer is that AI-assisted work requires review the same way any draft does. The risk is not unique to AI; it is the same risk that exists when any staff member produces a first draft without review.

"We cannot afford another technology subscription."

Some AI tools have no-cost plans that are genuinely useful. Others have nonprofit pricing. The real cost question is whether the staff time saved justifies the tool cost, and that math is usually favorable for high-volume writing tasks. Coming in with a specific cost estimate and a specific time-savings estimate makes this a real conversation instead of a theoretical one.

"This feels like it replaces people."

For most nonprofits, AI tools are replacing tasks within jobs, not jobs themselves. A case manager who spends less time on documentation has more time for direct service. That framing matters, and it should be explicit. If the organization is genuinely concerned about this, it is worth naming

directly: here is what we will and will not use AI for, and here is how we will make sure staff feel supported through the change.

What a pilot looks like

The least risky way to make a case for AI internally is to run a small pilot and let the results do the talking. A pilot does not require board approval, a policy document, or a significant budget commitment. It requires a willing staff member, a specific task, a time-boxed experiment, and a plan to evaluate what happened.

1 Choose one task with a clear time cost.

Grant report narrative drafts, board meeting minutes, donor acknowledgment letters, and job postings are all good candidates. Pick something that happens regularly and that the person doing it finds tedious.

2 Choose one tool and give it a real try for four weeks.

The learning curve is real. Two weeks is not long enough to know whether a tool is useful. Four weeks gives enough time to get past initial awkwardness and see what the tool can actually do.

3 Track time before and after.

A simple log is enough. You do not need a formal evaluation framework. You need to be able to say, at the end of the pilot, how much time the task took before and how much it takes now.

4 Report back honestly.

If it helped, say so and say by how much. If it did not, say that too. A failed pilot that is reported honestly builds more trust than an overstated success.

Questions your board will ask

BE READY FOR THESE

What are we doing with client data? Have a specific answer: what goes in, what does not, and what the vendor's data policy says.

What does this cost? Know the number, know whether nonprofit pricing applies, and know how it compares to the staff time it replaces.

What happens if the vendor changes or goes away? Know your data portability situation and have a plain answer about continuity risk.

Who is responsible for reviewing what comes out of it? Have a named process, not a general assurance that staff will be careful.

How will we know if it's working? Have a metric in mind before you start, even a simple one.

The cost of not engaging

One argument that is often left out of internal conversations is the cost of staying where you are. Staff are already using AI tools, whether or not the organization has a policy about it. The question is not whether AI is entering your organization. It is whether the organization is guiding how it is used or discovering after the fact what has been happening.

Nonprofits that engage with AI proactively, with appropriate caution, are in a better position than those that either rush in without thinking or hold back until the landscape forces their hand. The goal is not to be early or to be last. It is to be deliberate — and deliberate decisions require the conversation to happen at all.

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